

Session 18: Hyperlinks in the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- Repeated words can signal a theme and link chapters that are in sequence to each other or in different parts of the Hebrew Bible.
- The portrait of Jonah in [chapter 4](#) is hyperlinked to the portrait of Elijah in [1 Kings 19](#). The Elijah story itself also hyperlinks to the golden calf story in Exodus.
- The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature for a lifetime. Every word, every episode, and every scene is intentional—you'll never stop noticing threads and connections.

Literary Symmetry

This same kind of juxtaposition happens between literary units that are not side by side but connected by literary symmetry and key word links.

An example of this from Jonah can be seen in the use of “arise, go call” in [chapters 1](#) and [3](#), in the use of “pray” in chapters [2](#) and [4](#), and in the use of “perish” in chapters 1 and 3.

“Prose narrative naturally expects linear reading, i.e., progressive reading from one unit to the next (from A to B to C, etc.) as the story unfolds through the text. Symmetrically organized narrative offers additional avenues for interpretive access as well ... because it invites multi-level comparison. We can examine why units are placed next to one another (A and B), but also are invited to mentally juxtaposed symmetrically paired units (A and A'). This pattern also invites comparison between entire matching sequences (ABC and A'B'C'). Different symmetrical patterns can indicate reversal (ABCDC'B'A'), progression (ABC/A'B'C'), or even intensification (ABC/A'B'C'D).”

Walsh, Jerome (2001). [Style and Structure in Biblical Hebrew Narrative](#). Liturgical Press. 12.

Chapter 1

God - Jonah - The Sailors

- 1:1-2 *"And the word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... 'Arise, go to Nineveh ...'"*
- 1:3 *"And Jonah arose to flee to Tarshish."*
- 1:5 *Sailors: They were afraid and every man cried out to his god.*
- 1:6 *Captain: "Call out to your God; perhaps God will consider and we will not perish."*
- 1:9 *Jonah: "I fear Yahweh, the God ... who made the sea and the dry land."*

Jonah "went down" 3X

The sailors "sacrifice" and "vow vows"

- 1:13 *The sailors rowed to turn back to land.*
- 1:15 *They picked up Jonah and threw him into the sea, and the sea stopped its raging.*
- 1:16 *And the men feared Yahweh a great fear ...*

Chapter 2

Jonah's Prayer to God

- 2:1 *"And Jonah prayed to God ... from the deep abyss."*
- 1:17 *God "appoints" a fish to swallow Jonah.*
- 2:1 *Jonah is "delivered" by the fish's belly.*

"I went down to the underworld."

"I will sacrifice to you; I will pay my vows."

- 2:2-9 *Jonah offers thanks to God for saving his life.*
- 2:9 *Jonah praises God for offering his salvation.*
- 2:10 *The fish responds to Jonah's prayer by vomiting.*

Chapter 3

God - Jonah - The Ninevites

- 3:1-2 *"And the word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... 'Arise, go to Nineveh ...'"*
- 3:3 *And Jonah arose and went to Nineveh.*
- 3:5 *Ninevites: The people believed in God and called a fast.*
- 3:8-9 *King: "Let them call out to God ... he may turn and relent ... and we will not perish!"*
- 3:4 *Jonah: "Forty days and Nineveh will be turned over!"*

Will God repent from his heat-anger?

They turned back from their evil ways.

- 3:8 *"Let each one turn back from his wicked way ..."*
- 3:10 *"And God relented concerning the evil which he said he would do to them, and he did not do it."*
- 4:1 *"And it was evil to Jonah, a great evil."*

Chapter 4

Jonah's Prayer to God

- 4:2, 5 *"And Jonah prayed to God ... in the east of the city."*
- 4:6-8 *God "appoints" the plant, worm, and wind: to shade Jonah, eat a plant, and burn Jonah.*
- 4:5 *Jonah is "delivered" by his "shelter."*

And Jonah had heat-anger.

I knew that you'd repent concerning evil!

- 4:3, 8 *Jonah asks God to take his life.*
- 4:2 *Jonah criticizes God for offering his compassion.*
- 4:7 *The worm responds to Jonah's prayer by eating.*

Literary Techniques for Analyzing Literary Design and Thematic Development

Intertextual Hyperlinks and Dynamic Analogies

The biblical authors regularly invite comparison and analogies between different sections of the Hebrew Scriptures. They do this in a manner similar to hyperlinks on a web page, where a key word or well-known allusive phrase will signal to the reader that the other text is meant to be recalled and connected thematically to the present text.

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
Elijah flees from Jezebel after defeating the prophets of Baal on Mt. Carmel	Jonah flees from God's call to go to Nineveh
Elijah walks one day into the wilderness (19:4a)	Jonah walks one day into Nineveh (3:4) Jonah goes east of Nineveh (4:5)
Elijah "asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (19:4b)	"And now, Yahweh, please take my life (נפשי) from me, for good is my death more than my life" (4:3) "And he asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (4:8)
"And he lay down and he slept (וישכב ויישן), and look, an angel touching him, and he said, 'Arise (קום), eat!'" (19:5)	"And [Jonah] lay down and he slept (וישכב וירדם) ... And the captain said ... 'Arise (קום) call on your God!'" (1:5-6)
Elijah journeys 40 days to Mt. Horeb (Mount Sinai) (19:8)	Jonah announces 40 days until Nineveh's destruction (3:4)
God asks Elijah two times why he has come to Mt. Horeb (19:9, 13)	God asks two times if it is good that Jonah is angry at his mercy (4:4, 9)
Elijah gives the same exaggerated, self-pitying answer two times (19:10, 14)	Jonah gives the same pathetic and selfish answer two times (4:2, 9)
Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
God communicates with Elijah through symbolic natural phenomena (wind, earthquake, lightning) (19:11-12)	God communicates with Jonah through symbolic natural phenomena (plant, worm, wind) (4:6-8)
God counters Elijah's self-pity: You are not the only faithful Israelite, I have 7,000 others (19:18)	God counters Jonah's self-pity: You had pity on this plant, shouldn't I have pity on a great city? (4:10-11)
<i>Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Exodus 14:31	The Sailors and Ninevites
After the Israelites are rescued from the sea	Jonah is rescued from the sea
And the Israelites saw the great hand which Yahweh acted against Egypt and the people feared Yahweh (וִירָאוּ הָעָם אֶת־יְהוָה) and they believed in Yahweh (וַיֵּאֱמִינוּ בַיהוָה) and in Moses his servant.	1:16: And the sailors feared Yahweh (וִירָאוּ ... אֶת־יְהוָה) a great fear ...
	3:5: And the men of Nineveh believed in God (וַיֵּאֱמִינוּ בֵּאלֹהִים).
<i>Dynamic Analogy in Jonah.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Criteria for identifying intertextual hyperlinks (Leonard, 2008)

1. Clusters of shared words or phrases
2. Shared language that consists of distinct vocabulary
3. Shared language within thematically similar contexts
4. Shared language between units that are united by other literary strategies (similar plot, themes, settings)

Inversion/Reflection Stories

This is “a strategy used by biblical narrators to aid the reader in evaluating characters ... It’s one of the many instances of intertextuality so common in biblical literature. The narrators use many overt allusions to other narratives known to them and to their audience ... in order to shape a character as the antithesis of a character in another narrative. The new creation awakens in the reader undeniable associations to the source-story; the relationship between the new narrative and its source is like that between an image and its mirrored reflection: the reflection inverts the storyline of the original narrative ... The discerning reader will consider the implicit relation between the two narratives—the original and its reflection—and observe how the new character behaves contrary to the character upon which he or she is modeled. The reader is being asked to evaluate the new hero in light of the model, both with regard to action and to lack of action.

In addition, the comparison created between the two stories sheds new light on the source story and its protagonist. I call these 'inverted' stories reflection stories.”
Zakovitch, Yair (1993). [Through the Looking Glass: Reflections/Inversions of Genesis Stories in the Bible](#). Brill.

Narrative Analogy and Design Patterns

Robert Alter gives the example of cowboy western films. What if 1,200 years from now, post-apocalyptic archaeologists discover an old Hollywood film vault with dozens of old western films? They'd watch and analyze them and notice patterns.

“In eleven films, the sheriff hero has the same anomalous neurological trait of hyperreflexivity—no matter what the situation in which his adversaries confront him, he is always able to pull his gun out its holster and fire before they can, even if they're already poised with their own weapons ... But, in the twelfth film, the sheriff has an injured arm and instead of a pistol he uses a rifle that he carries, slung over his back ... Contemporary viewers of westerns recognize the convention without even having to name it as such. Much of our pleasure in watching westerns derives from our awareness that the hero, however sinister the dangers looming ahead, leads a charmed life that he will always in the end prove himself more successful than his enemies ... For us, the repetitive pattern across all these cinematic works is not an enigma to be explained, but a necessary condition for telling a story within expected conventions of the film medium. With our easy knowledge of the patterns, we naturally see the point of the twelfth sheriff, and we can spot the pattern of the quick-draw sheriff by its absence.”

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books.

Symphonic Development of Themes Through Narrative Analogy

“A musical approach to Scripture encompasses a number of aspects, each of which can help us see Scripture in a fresh light ... One aspect of the music metaphor is the relationship between melody and harmony. The Bible has a clear storyline, a melody, but it also has a range of individual and corporate stories that run together, sometimes taking center stage, sometimes fading into the background, providing harmony and counterpoint, treble and bass, height and depth, in such a way that no single writer (or musician) could possibly represent it all. Studying the Bible is about exploring the detail of the harmony — Why is the oboe, or Obadiah, doing that, and how does it contribute to the whole piece?—without losing sight of the melody ... Another (and more subtle) aspect is the interplay between rhythm and meter. Meter is the underlying time structure of a piece—one, two, three, four, one, two, three, four—and although it may vary within the piece, it provides a grounding in time, a sense of orientation, for the listener. Rhythm is the structure of the sound you actually hear— boom, ba-cha, boom, boom, ba-cha— which may involve a number of notes in one beat, or a number of beats without notes. The rhythm rides the meter like a surfer rides a wave, playing, doing its own thing, but always mindful of and constrained by the steady movement underneath. As the Bible commences with its overture, we hear a melody, and a regular rhythm begins. As things develop, various harmonies and disharmonies arise ... leaving us listeners to wonder what the Composer is doing. And a good Composer allows dissonance to create anticipation for the right time to heal it. Then the melody returns, cutting through the cacophony and bringing a temporary sense of resolution. To someone who has never heard the piece before, some moments can even sound like the symphony is fully resolved and is about to finish (a new reader of the Bible could easily think the tension is resolved, for instance, upon the entrance into the Promised Land or David's coronation). Yet these

temporary resolutions produce tensions of their own, which point forward to more complexities, and beyond them, to further resolutions. Throughout the Bible, as time metronomically marches on, the rhythms of Scripture continue to be accented, with particular days and festivals highlighting rest and freedom, law and atonement. But every bar, every cadence, every pause, heightens the sense that the piece is still incomplete. Eventually, after an uncomfortably long silence, the score builds to a massive crescendo in Jesus the Messiah, as the various themes come together and resolve in a fashion that nobody could have quite imagined, but yet seems completely natural ... Only at the finale, when the Christ-crescendo is recapitulated and the instruments are joined by earthly and angelic choirs, do we ultimately see the full scope of the Composer's vision. As such, a musical reading of Scripture does more justice to the way Scripture actually works. Scriptural typology is more like a piece of music: familiar themes like temple, kingdom, exodus, judgment, and sacrifice keep recurring, but always slightly differently. The judgment of Jerusalem is not just a 'picture' or 'shadow' of the last day; nor is it simply a dramatic 'event' that happens once and then is no more. It is somehow a part of the future judgment, a foretaste of it, and yet at the same time historically distinct from it. The final resolution, when it comes, is both familiar and new at the same time. It is, in that sense, musical."

Roberts, Alastair J. and Wilson, Andrew (2018). [*Echoes of Exodus: Tracing Themes of Redemption Through Scripture*](#). Crossway.

A Series of Questions To Ask of Every Literary Unit

1. What is the literary design of the unit?
2. What are the key words and wordplay within each literary unit?
3. What are the relationships and links to the juxtaposed literary units?
4. What are the relationships and links to symmetrically-paired units?
5. What are the intertextual relationships and links within the unit?
6. What are the relationships and links to inner-book patterns?
7. What are the relationships and links to inner-TaNaK patterns?

Reflection Question

How is Jonah like Elijah or Moses? How is he not like them? How do you think these similarities or differences affect our perspective on the character of Jonah?